

▶ **AS WE UNHURRIEDLY** head for the photo shoot for this article, the query comes, softly: “Do we really need to do this?” On affirmation from this correspondent, our protagonist resigns himself to his fate, and poses, hesitant and unsure, for a series of photos taken by *BT*’s cheery photographer. Sensing the opportunity, his communication personnel also jump into the act, happily snapping away with their phone cameras, lamenting the fact that their boss doesn’t pose for the cameras for internal events and messages. The shyness in the photo shoot is quite contrary to the interview that precedes it, where the boss takes questions with a quiet, confident calm, parrying curveballs with assured élan. Quite clearly, Dheeraj Gopichand Hinduja is more interested in focussing on his work and letting others take the limelight, a trait that comes through clearly in the interview, where he repeatedly emphasises the key role played by his people in the performance of Ashok Leyland, India’s third-biggest manufacturer of commercial vehicles (after Tata Motors and Mahindra & Mahindra or M&M) and second-biggest manufacturer of trucks (after Tata Motors).

It is a performance that the 52-year-old third-generation scion of the UK-based Hinduja family, frequently ranked among the richest in the UK, can be justifiably proud of. Ashok Leyland, the flagship company of the Hinduja group that employs more than 100,000 people across several countries in a wide array of businesses, including automotive, energy, infrastructure, finance & banking, IT & ITES, media and healthcare, has just turned the corner and roared into the black, with its consolidated net profits clocking ₹1,362 crore in FY23, after suffering losses of ₹285 crore in FY22 and ₹70 crore in FY21. On the way, it has had to deal with multiple challenges, including a surprising fall in demand before Covid-19, then an expected fall in demand during the pandemic amid several other bottlenecks wrought by it, and a churn in the CEO office, among other things.

Ashok Leyland waged a multi-front revival strategy. “The important thing we’ve been doing, knowing that the industry goes through cycles, is to ensure



SHENU AGARWAL
MD & CEO, ASHOK
LEYLAND LTD

“There is a large segment—sub-2 tonnes—where we are not there, and it is also quite profitable. So, this is one area we have been contemplating whether we should get in or not for the past few years”



GOPAL MAHADEVAN
CFO AND WHOLE TIME
DIRECTOR, ASHOK
LEYLAND LTD

“We have been able to raise prices [in the current year] even as we gain market share, and that gain has not been just a number, it has been the increase in presence across the country”

that the growth momentum and the profitability of the company should not suffer. And that’s why we started diversifying into different segments like LCVs (light commercial vehicles), international operations, our parts business, defence business, power solution business,” says the mild-mannered Hinduja, a BSc (Hons) graduate in economics and history from University College, London, and an MBA graduate from Imperial College, London University. The company launched new platforms and products in the midst of the pandemic, strengthened its people practices and created a fresh programme for developing managers, widened its reach

THE GROWTH PATH

▶ **Ashok Leyland’s commercial vehicle sales in India shot up more than 54 per cent in FY23**

▶ **The company’s consolidated net income has moved into positive territory after two fiscals of losses**